Root Crops

Carrot.

HARVEST SEASONS
Summer / Autumn



Fresh carrots have a sweet, earthy flavour rarely matched by shop-bought roots. Establishment can be tricky: germination is slow and slugs attack seedlings. Deep, fine, stone-free soil helps roots grow straight and tender; light soil or compost-filled no-dig beds can work well. Sow short successions for early-summer to autumn harvests. Steady moisture, careful thinning and carrot-fly protection make a big difference. Fresh manure, compaction, stones, drought and rough handling can leave roots forked, tough or damaged.

Quick facts

Sow
Apr – Jun

Harvest
Aug – Oct

Plant spacing Thin to 2-3 in. apart

Germination
17 days

Depth
1/2 in.

Ready in Early ~12; maincrop ~16 weeks from sowing

Row spacing
6 in. between rows

Yield (10 ft row)
early: 8 lb; maincrop: 10 lb

Growing calendar

	J	F	M	A	M	J	J	A	S	O	N	D
SOW			●	●	●	●		●				
HARVEST						●	●	●	●	●	●	●

Bright: usual months · Muted: less usual

Core needs

1 = low · 5 = high

Sun	4/5
Water	3/5
Nutrition	2/5

Recommended varieties

SHORT-ROOTED
Early Nantes 2
A familiar early carrot with cylindrical roots. A practical general-purpose choice for successive sowings and tender young carrots.

INTERMEDIATE-ROOTED
Autumn King
A maincrop carrot producing substantial roots for autumn lifting and storage. Suits gardeners wanting a later, heavier crop.

INTERMEDIATE-ROOTED
Chantenay Red Cored
A shorter, broad-shouldered carrot. A useful alternative where very long-rooted varieties are less convenient to grow.

Key risks

Carrot Fly
Tell-tale signs on carrots are reddish leaves which wilt in sunny weather and later turn yellow.

Fanging
Fanging is usually caused by adding manure or compost to the soil shortly before seed sowing.

Small Roots
Aphids and virus will stunt growth and reduce yield, but even in the absence of pests and diseases many gardeners produce disappointingly small carrots.

Splitting
Much more serious than fanging of carrots, because the roots will not store.

Onion Family

Onions and Shallots.

HARVEST SEASONS
Summer / Autumn



Grow onions and shallots for fresh bulbs, salads, pickles and winter stores. Spring sets offer a simple start; seed gives more choice of colour, size and season. Shallots usually form clusters; overwintered onions crop earlier. All need clean, fertile ground and thorough drying for storage. Timings and bolting risk vary.

Quick facts

Sow
Feb – Apr; Aug

Germination
21 days

Row spacing
Between rows: Onions and shallots 12 in.; salad onions 8 in.

Harvest
Jun – Sep

Seed depth
5/8 in.

Yield (10 ft row)
8 lb

Plant spacing Between plants: Salad onions 1 in.; single seed-grown onions or shallots 4 in.; onion sets 4–6 in.; onion module clumps 6 in.; shallot sets or module clumps 6–8 in.

Ready in From planting: sets ~20 weeks, shallots ~18; from sowing: spring ~22, August ~46 weeks

Growing calendar

	J	F	M	A	M	J	J	A	S	O	N	D
SOW	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●			
HARVEST					●	●	●	●	●	●		

Bright: usual months · Muted: less usual

Core needs

1 = low · 5 = high

Sun	4/5
Water	3/5
Nutrition	3/5

Recommended varieties

BULB ONIONS
Red Baron
Red bulbs for salads and cooking; available as seed or sets.

BULB ONIONS
Sturon
A dependable brown storage onion, usually grown from sets.

BULB ONIONS
Ailsa Craig
Large, mild bulbs from seed; useful in the kitchen rather than for long winter storage.

SALAD ONIONS
White Lisbon
A familiar salad onion with slender white stems; sow small batches for steady young pickings.

SHALLOTS
Jermor
A flavoursome, copper-skinned shallot with elongated bulbs, usually grown from sets.

SHALLOTS
Zebrune
A banana shallot from seed; elongated bulbs are easy to slice.

Key risks

White Rot (Mouldy Nose)
White rot affects onions, shallots, garlic and leeks.

Allium Leaf Miner
Adult flies make distinctive rows of small white feeding punctures on allium leaves.

Bolting
Prolonged cold can trigger early flowering, especially in large sets or weather-checked young plants.

Leek Moth
Leek-moth caterpillars can mine onion and shallot leaves and damage bulbs.

Oriental Leaves.

HARVEST SEASONS
Summer / Autumn



Oriental leaves are quick salad and stir-fry crops, mostly brassicas: Chinese cabbage, leaf radish, mibuna, mizuna, mustards, pak choi and shungiku. Many give baby leaves within a month. Late-summer sowings often escape the worst flea beetle damage and fill the autumn salad gap; some leafy types crop into winter under cover. These tender, flavoursome greens are for fresh use, not long storage.

Quick facts

Sow
Jul – Aug

Harvest
Aug – Nov

Row spacing
Small-leaf: 10 in.; pak choi: 12 in.; Chinese cabbage: 18 in.

Depth Mizuna/mibuna, Chinese cabbage: about ½ in.; pak choi: ¾ in.; others: see packet.

Plant spacing Baby leaves: 4–6 in.; larger leaves: 8 in.; mature pak choi/cabbage hearts: 12 in.

Ready in From sowing: baby leaves ~3–4 weeks; pak choi ~6; cabbage hearts ~10 weeks

Growing calendar

	J	F	M	A	M	J	J	A	S	O	N	D
SOW			●	●	●	●	●	●	●			
HARVEST	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●

Bright: usual months · Muted: less usual

Core needs

1 = low · 5 = high

Sun	3/5
Water	4/5
Nutrition	3/5

Recommended varieties

Mizuna
Quick Japanese leaf with finely cut foliage and mild mustard flavour for salads or brief cooking.

Mibuna
Narrow, strap-like Japanese green. Use young leaves in salads, larger ones in stir-fries.

Red Frills mustard
Finely divided, peppery red mustard. Pick young and mix with milder salad leaves.

Joi Choi
Crisp white-stalked pak choi with green leaves. Pick young for salads, larger for stir-fries.

Tatsoi
Low rosettes of dark leaves for baby-leaf salads and quick cooking.

Key risks

FLEA BEETLE
Flea beetles make small round holes in young brassica leaves, especially during warm, dry weather.

SLUGS
Slugs chew leaves and seedlings, especially pak choi in damp conditions.

BOLTING
Cold checks, long days, heat or drought can encourage premature flowering, depending on the species and variety.

CABBAGE CATERPILLARS
Chinese cabbage and other brassica leaves may be attacked by caterpillars.

Stalks & Shoots

Florence Fennel.

HARVEST SEASONS
Summer / Autumn



Florence fennel, or bulb fennel, is a sweet, aniseed-flavoured umbellifer grown for the swollen bases of its leaf-stalks. It belongs to the same broad family as carrot, parsnip and celeriac, but is eaten quite differently: sliced raw in salads, cooked gently for a soft creamy flavour, or used in soups and ratatouille. The feathery leaves are also edible, with a gentle aniseed flavour. Modern varieties have made it easier to grow by reducing the tendency to bolt before useful bulbs form. Match the variety to its sowing season and keep young plants growing steadily: drought, crowding or root checks can give stemmy plants instead of juicy bulbs. Summer sowings after an early crop are useful for autumn harvesting. Harvest while the bulbs are tender, before they become fibrous, stemmy or frosted.

Quick facts

Sow
Jun – Jul

Harvest
Jul – Oct

Plant spacing 12 in. between plants

Depth
5/8 in.

Row spacing
12 in. between rows

Ready in From sowing: baby bulbs ~6 weeks; full bulbs 12–16 weeks

Growing calendar

	J	F	M	A	M	J	J	A	S	O	N	D
SOW												
HARVEST												

Bright: usual months · Muted: less usual

Core needs

1 = low · 5 = high

Sun	4/5
Water	4/5
Nutrition	4/5

Recommended varieties

Zefa Fino

An established Florence fennel grown for swollen leaf bases. Keep growth steady with moisture and use appropriate sowing dates.

Romanesco

A traditional Florence fennel with substantial bulbs. Retain for gardeners who prefer a familiar non-hybrid selection.

Rondo F1

A modern Florence fennel producing rounded bulbs. A useful addition to the established open-pollinated choices.

Key risks

BOLTING OR STEMMY BULBS

Cold while young, drought and root disturbance can trigger premature flowering.

SMALL OR DRY BULBS

Drought and poor fertility produce small, less juicy bulbs.

LOWER SHEATH ROT

Lower sheaths may soften and decay.

FROST

Hard frost damages bulbs.